

Q.8a (20 marks): Explain Tech-determinism approach of Leslie White in Anthropology. Also explain how Sahlins and...

explain how Sahlins and Service reconciled the debate between White and Steward. (20 marks)

Leslie White was an American anthropologist from Neo-evolutionist school of anthropology.

Works : ① Science of Culture.
② Evolution of culture.

Tech-determinism approach of Leslie White

① Evolution of a culture followed unilinear pattern of evolution $\Rightarrow$ Savagery $\rightarrow$ Barbarism $\downarrow$ Civilisation.

② This pattern of change was based on type of energy harnessed in each stage

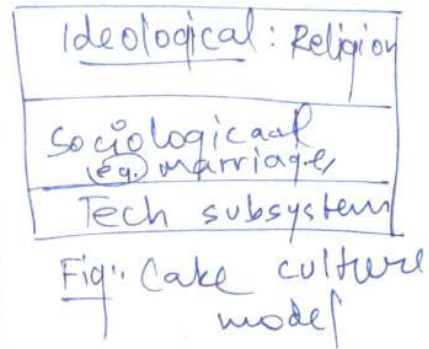
- Savagery $\rightarrow$ Human Muscle energy (eg. Hunting).
- Barbarism $\rightarrow$ Use of animal and plant energy (eg. Agriculture).
- Civilisation $\rightarrow$ Use of new energy forms (eg. Machine energy like steam).

7.c) Explain Cultural materialism school of thought in Anthropology. (15 marks)

- (1) The type of energy harnessed & divided based upon the quality and quantity of energy harnessed
- (2) Both above parameters. depend upon efficiency of harnessing energy. $\Rightarrow$ Technology employed determines
- (3) Based on this - he gave his idea that technology determines culture change. tech-determinism of culture.
- (4) Law of culture change $\Rightarrow$ $E \times T = C$
 E = Energy harnessed. (total)
 T = Technology which determines efficiency.
 C = Cultural development

Ex	Energy	Techn	culture	Example.
	Low	Low	Low	tribes.
	High	Low	Low	Africa
	High	High.	High	western nations

⑧ Based on tech-determinism, he said the social and Ideological aspects get affected. When technology changes, other aspects adapt to the change.



Steward criticized white for being generalized.

later Julian Steward brought Cultural Ecology approach which proposed multilinear cultural evolution and idea that tech-environment determines culture core. White criticized for confusing history and evolution.

The above debate was reconciled by Sahlins (student of Steward) and Service (White's student)

through idea of General and Specific Evolution of Culture

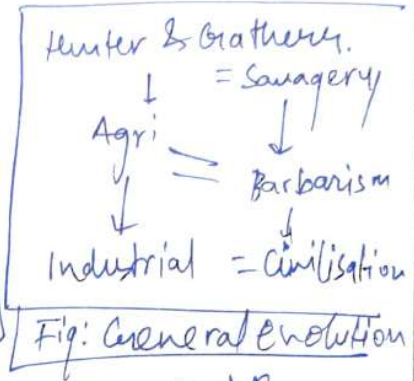
① Evolution has dual character as per them.

② First it moves stage by stage

In a unilinear fashion from lower to higher forms.

③ There can be skipping of stages.

→ This is General Evolution



④ At the same time evolution can happen with diversity with each culture taking different adaptations for evolving.

⇒ This is Specific Evolution

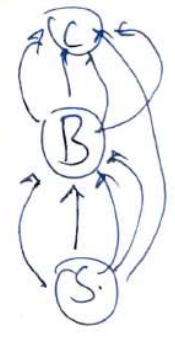


Fig: Specific Evolution

They merged both white and Steward's idea showing that cultural evolution is possible.

In multiple ways